

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

1993-10-19

To an individual b ahá'í

dear b ahá'í friend,

about the term "b ahá'í scholarship." . . .

The house of justice suggests that the issues raised in your letter might best be considered in light of the statements in the bahá'í writings which disclose the relationship between the revelation of bahá'u'lláh and the knowledge which is acquired as a result of scholarly endeavors. bahá'u'lláh asserts that:

unveiled and unconcealed, this wronged one hath, at all times,

proclaimed before the face of all the peoples of the world that which will serve as the key for unlocking the doors of sciences, of arts, of knowledge, of well-being, of prosperity and wealth. . . .

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it is evident that the bahá'í writings illuminate all areas of human endeavor and all academic disciplines. Those who have been privileged to rec-

169-1. Tb, p. 96.168.3

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59ognize the station of bahá'u'lláh have the bounty of access to a revelation which casts light upon all aspects of thought and inquiry, and are enjoined to use the understanding which they obtain from their immersion in the holy writings to advance the interests of the faith.

Those believers with the capacity and opportunity to do so have repeatedly been encouraged in their pursuit of academic studies by which they are not only equipped to render much-needed services to the faith, but are also provided with the means to acquire a profound insight into the mean-

ing and the implications of the bahá'í Teachings. They discover also that the perceptions gained from a deeper understanding of the revelation of bahá'u'lláh clarify the subjects of their academic inquiry.

it is useful to review a number of statements written by Shoghi effendi on this subject. To a believer who had completed advanced academic studies in a subject related to the Teachings the guardian stated, in a letter written on his behalf:

it is hoped that all the bahá'í students will follow the noble example you have set before them and will, henceforth, be led to investigate and analyze the principles of the faith and to correlate them with the modern aspects of philosophy and science. every intelligent and thoughtful young bahá'í should always approach the cause in this way, for therein lies the very essence of the principle of independent investigation of truth. when he was informed of the enrollment of a scientist in the faith, the response set out in the letter written on his behalf was:

we need very much the sound, sane, element of thinking which a scientifically trained mind has to offer. when such intellectual powers are linked to deep faith a tremendous teaching potential is created. . . .

his secretary wrote, on another occasion, that:

Shoghi effendi has for years urged the bahá'ís (who asked his advice, and in general also) to study history, economics, sociology, etc., in order to be au courant with all the progressive movements and thoughts being put forth today, and so that they could correlate these to the bahá'í teachings. what he wants the bahá'ís to do is to study 169.4

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169.6a

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169.7a

m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

60more, not to study less. The more general knowledge, scientific and otherwise, they possess, the better. likewise he is constantly urging

them to really study the bahá'í teachings more deeply.169-2

in the simultaneous endeavor to pursue their studies and to delve deeply into the bahá'í Teachings, believers are enjoined to maintain a keen awareness that the revelation of bahá'u'lláh is the standard of truth against which

all other views and conclusions are to be measured. They are urged to be modest about their accomplishments, and to bear in mind always the statement of bahá'u'lláh that:

The heart must needs therefore be cleansed from the idle sayings

of men, and sanctified from every earthly affection, so that it may discover the hidden meaning of divine inspiration, and become the

treasury of the mysteries of divine knowledge.

169-3

At this early stage in the development of the faith, it would not be useful

to propound a highly restrictive definition of the term "bahá'í scholarship."

in a letter written on behalf of the house of justice to an Association for

bahá'í Studies recently, it is stated that:

The house of justice advises you not to attempt to define too nar-

rowly the form that bahá'í scholarship should take, or the approach

that scholars should adopt. rather should you strive to develop within

your Association respect for a wide range of approaches and endeavors.

No doubt there will be some bahá'ís who will wish to work in

isolation, while others will desire consultation and collaboration with those having similar interests. your aim should be to promote an at-

mosphere of mutual respect and tolerance within which will be in-

cluded scholars whose principal interest is in theological issues as well

as those scholars whose interests lie in relating the insights provided by the bahá'í teachings to contemporary thought in the arts and sciences.

A similar diversity should characterize the endeavors pursued by

bahá'í scholars, accommodating their interests and skills as well as

169-2. cc 1:506.

169-3. ki, ¶77 .169.8

169.8a

169.9

169.9a

169.9b

61the needs of the faith. The course of world events, the development of new trends of thought and the extension of the teaching work all tend to highlight attractive and beneficial areas to which bahá'í scholars might well direct their attention. likewise, the expansion of the activities of the bahá'í international community in its relationship with united Nations agencies and other international bodies creates attractive opportunities for scholars to make a direct and highly valued contribution to the enhancement of the prestige of the faith and to its proclamation within an influential and receptive stratum of society. As the bahá'í community continues to emerge inexorably from obscu-

rity, it will be confronted by enemies, from both within and without, whose aim will be to malign and misrepresent its principles, so that its admirers might be disillusioned and the faith of its adherents might be

shaken; bahá'í scholars have a vital role to play in the defense of the faith through their contribution to anticipatory measures and their response to defamatory accusations leveled against the f aith.

Thus, there should be room within the scope of bahá'í scholarship to accommodate not only those who are interested in theological issues and in the historical origins of the faith, but also those who are interested in relating the bahá'í Teachings to their field of academic or professional interest, as well as those believers who may lack formal academic qualifications but who have, through their perceptive study of the Teachings, acquired insights which are of interest to others.

Since you have raised the question of whether physics is more than tangentially related to bahá'í issues, you might consider the following comments of a well-known scientific thinker, who is not a bahá'í, about the correlation between the bahá'í Teachings and recent developments in the physical sciences:

in our times we can only survive, and our civilization can only flower, if we reorient the conventional wisdom and achieve the new insights which have been proclaimed by the bahá'í faith and which are now also supported by the latest discoveries of the empirical sciences. bahá'ís proclaim that the most important condition that can bring about peace is unity—the unity of families, of nations, and of the

great currents of thought and inquiry that we denote science and religion. maturity, in turn, is a prerequisite for such unity. This is 169.10

169.11

169.11a

169.11b

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62evolutionary thinking, and its validity is shown by the new theories which emerge from nonequilibrium thermodynamics, dynamical systems theory, cybernetics, and the related sciences of complexity.

They are supported by detailed empirical investigations in such fields as physical cosmology, paleobiological macroevolutionary theory, and new trends in historiography.

The house of justice wishes to avoid use of the terms “bahá’í scholar-ship” and “bahá’í scholars” in an exclusive sense, which would effectively establish a demarcation between those admitted into this category and those denied entrance to it. it is clear that such terms are relative, and that what is a worthy scholarly endeavor by a bahá’í, when compared to the activities of those with whom he is in contact, may well be regarded as of vastly lesser significance when measured against the accomplishments of the outstanding scholars which the faith has produced. The house of justice seeks the creation of a bahá’í community in which the members encourage each other, where there is respect for accomplishment, and a common realization that every one is, in his or her own way, seeking to acquire a deeper understanding of the revelation of bahá’u’lláh and to contribute to the advancement of the faith.

with loving bahá’í greetings,

Department of the Secretariat

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Reformat of The Bahá’í World Series

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]